Board Policy 6.xx.xxx-P

Digital Device and Screen Use Policy

I. PURPOSE

This Policy establishes rules for the evaluation, deployment, and use of digital technologies and screen-based devices within Portland Public Schools. It supports PPS's Graduate Portrait and Portland Public Schools' mission to provide an equitable, high-quality education by safeguarding students' physical, social-emotional, and cognitive development, and by ensuring that adopted technologies enhance, rather than diminish, learning outcomes and instructional time.

Through clear, consistent, age-appropriate expectations, this Policy reflects a shared responsibility among schools, families, and students to promote academic focus, critical thinking, and healthy, lifelong learning habits, preparing students to be responsible digital citizens throughout their school years and beyond.

II. DEFINITIONS

A. **Screen Time:** Screen Time refers to the amount of time a student is expected to view or interact with Device displays, including structured educational technology used for instruction and unstructured or non-instructional media. Screen Time does not include use of assistive technology required to provide a student with access to instruction or PPS services.

B. **Device:** As used in this policy, a Device means any PPS-owned, PPS-issued, or PPS-managed laptop, desktop computer, tablet, mobile phone, wearable device, virtual or augmented reality equipment, or other internet-connected hardware used to access PPS systems or instructional content.

C. **Educational Technology:** Educational Technology means software, digital applications, online services, websites, platforms, and other digital tools used for instructional, assessment, accessibility, safety, communication, or administrative purposes.

D. **Approved Educational Technology:** Approved Educational Technology means Educational Technology that PPS has reviewed and authorized under its educational technology approval process.

III. PRINCIPLES FOR SCREEN USE IN INSTRUCTION

A. **Screen Value:** Digital tools are implemented to support collaboration, creativity and curiosity with age-appropriate technology using learning science.

B. **Multi-Sensory Learning Priority.** Screens shall be used only for specific, approved purposes and shall not replace hands-on, experiential learning.

C. **Paper-Based Materials.** Paper materials shall be provided for reading, writing, and math instruction and assignments.

IV. GENERAL RULES AND RESTRICTIONS

The following rules shall apply to all digital device and screen use, except as dictated by state and federal requirements, Individualized Education Plans (IEPs), 504 plans, or

Personalized Education Plans (PEPs). The minutes below should be considered as a balance over the course of a unit of instruction to allow for flexibility

A. **Screen-free PK**. Individual screen use shall be prohibited for students in Pre-Kindergarten, except as required by state law.

B. **Centralized Device Use for 3-8**. Devices will be used to support specific in-class curriculum and learning activities and will not serve as the primary instructional medium, unless the student is participating in an online school or class approved or delivered by PPS. PPS will not operate a standard one-to-one take-home Device program for students in Pre-K through Grade 8.

   Students may take PPS Devices home only to address an identified instructional, accessibility, equity, or academic-support need, as approved by the principal or designee, or as required by an individualized education program ("IEP"), Section 504 plan, or applicable law. PPS will provide the student's parent or guardian with notice of the take-home arrangement and obtain an acknowledgment of applicable Device-use requirements. Failure to return an acknowledgment will not prevent PPS from providing a Device when the Device is required to provide the student with equal access, appropriate services, or legally required accommodations.

C. **K-8 Screen-Free Periods**. Recess, lunch, and passing periods will be screen- and device-free for grades K-8. Digital device and media use by students during these times, including movies, videos, gaming, or streaming content, may be allowed with administrative approval.

D. **Screen-Free Lunch for Grade 9-12**. The use of computers during high school lunch periods will be restricted to specific classrooms or library areas specifically designated as study halls.

E. **Instructional Flexibility.** PPS recognizes that some courses and learning experiences may require greater use of technology to achieve their instructional objectives. Screen time guidance should be applied with consideration for the unique requirements of courses such as computer science, graphic design, digital media arts, yearbook, engineering, career technical education pathways, film studies, and other technology-intensive programs. In these courses and programs, technology use may exceed general screen time recommendations when it is directly connected to curriculum, student creation, design, programming, production, research, or other active learning experiences. Such use should remain purposeful, instructionally aligned, and consistent with the goals of this policy.

F. **Offline Homework**. Homework assignments will be offered in a paper format whenever possible. Internet connectivity will not be required for the completion of homework assignments. This does not prohibit the use of a learning management system in grades 6-12 where "creation tools" (word processing, digital tools for production of learning) are in alignment with the focus of the graduate portrait.

G. **Use Only PPS-approved Digital Tools and Apps.** PPS-approved digital tools/apps will be vetted and approved to ensure they are safe, effective, and legal. Use of PPS teacher/student accounts to sign up for online accounts, digital tools, or apps outside of this process is prohibited. When students are using devices, all teachers, including substitutes, will utilize PPS-approved monitoring tools to monitor student screen use for appropriateness.

H. **Prohibition on Advertisement and Sales.** No advertisements will appear on any computer device or projected screen at school. Any device used at school, including those used by teachers or administrators, must be installed with premium ad

blockers. Furthermore, students and families will not be required to use any app or website that pushes “paid upgrades,” “premium services,” “in-app purchases,” or similar features.

I. **Educational Use of Video, Visual Media, and Other Content.** PPS devices will only be used for curriculum-aligned educational purposes that promote active student engagement during the school day. Video and device use should not be used as a substitute for teacher-led instruction, classroom engagement, or active learning experiences, and should be followed by opportunities for discussion, reflection, application, or other forms of student interaction. Non-educational use, including passive consumption for entertainment or video streaming, will be prohibited and blocked without administrator approval. Background video or visual media not aligned to active instruction should not be used. When not in active use, devices and projection screens should be off and away. Exceptions for specific disability related needs as outlined in an IEP or 504 plan are allowed.

J. **Gamified Learning Applications**. Gamified learning applications for academic subjects will be prohibited. Unless embedded within adopted curriculum. For purposes of this Policy, "gamified learning applications" means educational apps/software that rely on extrinsic game mechanics—including but not limited to points, badges, levels, leaderboards, or virtual rewards—for student engagement with academic content.

K. **Prohibition on Screen-Time as Reward**. Individual digital device use or screen time will not be used as a reward, incentive, or behavioral reinforcement for students.

L. **Platform and Content Restrictions.** PPS will filter Internet content in alignment with PPS policy. Staff will be provided classroom management tools that have the capability to block Internet websites**.** This should effectively restrict access to platforms and websites primarily designed for entertainment or passive consumption.

PPS will allow teacher-led use of YouTube for instructional purposes. PPS will block all other non-approved streaming platforms and non-approved gaming platforms. Platforms will only be permitted for educator-directed instructional use when they directly support curriculum-aligned learning objectives and follows an administrator approval process.

Staff may not direct students to create accounts, disclose personal information, upload student work, or use an educational technology service unless the service has been approved through the PPS educational technology review process. Staff may not accept click-though terms on behalf of PPS or use free applications, browser extensions, pilot programs, or artificial intelligence tools unless authorized under that process.

V. TIME LIMITATIONS ON DEVICE USE

The following rules will apply to all digital device and screen use, except as dictated by state and federal requirements, Individualized Education Plans (IEPs), 504 plans, or Personalized Education Plans (PEPs). The minutes below should be considered as a balance over the course of a unit of instruction to allow for flexibility.

A. **Screen-free PK**. Individual screen use will be prohibited for students in Pre-Kindergarten, except as required by state law.

B. **Grades K-8**:

i. Kindergarten: up to 45 minutes/week

ii. 1st grade: up to 60 minutes/week

iii. 2nd grade: up to 90 minutes/week

iv. 3rd grade through 5th grade: up to 225 minutes/week

v. 6th grade through 8th grade: up to 45 minutes/week per class. Across all classes, a maximum of 300 minutes/week, except for those courses where using technology is critical to students achieving the grade-level standards (e.g., STEM/STEAM courses, digital media courses)

vi. 9th grade through 12th grade: up to 60 minutes/week per class. Across all classes, a maximum of 480 minutes/week, except for those courses where using technology is critical to students achieving the grade-level standards (e.g., STEM/STEAM courses, digital media courses, dual credit courses)

C. **Exceptions:** Exceptions to the time limitations set forth in this Section may be granted under the following circumstances: (i) IEPs, 504 plans, or PEPs*; (ii) emergency situations requiring immediate communication or safety measures; (iii) temporary, unexpected teacher substitutions where prepared lesson plans necessitate screen-based instruction; (iv) special assemblies featuring guest speakers or presentations that require audiovisual components; (v) other special circumstances approved in advance by the principal.

*Online curriculum should not be used for specialized designed instruction (SDI) or modified curriculum unless there is a specific IEP goal that is being addressed.

D. **Instructional Flexibility.** PPS recognizes that some courses and learning experiences may require greater use of technology to achieve their instructional objectives. Screen time guidance should be applied with consideration for the unique requirements of courses such as computer science, graphic design, digital media arts, yearbook, engineering, career technical education pathways, film studies, and other technology-intensive programs. In these courses and programs, technology use may exceed general screen time recommendations when it is directly connected to curriculum, student creation, design, programming, production, research, or other active learning experiences. Such use should remain purposeful, instructionally aligned, and consistent with the goals of this policy.

VI. PROHIBITION OF ONE-TO-ONE DEVICES

A. **Prohibition on One-to-One Devices.** PPS will not issue individual devices to K-8 students. All student access to digital devices will be limited to shared devices in dedicated computer labs or supervised computer carts as set forth in Section IV of this Policy, except when indicated by a student's IEP or 504.

B. **Availability of "Home only" Devices for Optional Check-Out**. PPS will establish an "Opt-In" system where families may choose to receive a PPS-issued device for home use only, rather than requiring devices to travel between school and home daily. This will be on an as-needed basis, with written permission from a parent or guardian, for school-related work or access to online services. This will ensure equity in at-home access to computers and online services for all students, regardless of socioeconomic status.

C. **Exceptions.** Exceptions to this prohibition may be granted when the student has a documented need requiring individual device access, such as students under 504, PEPs, or Individualized Education Programs (IEPs), where use of assistive devices is explicitly required.

VII. DIGITAL LITERACY

PPS will integrate developmentally appropriate Digital Literacy instruction into the core curriculum for grades K–12. This instruction will focus on:

A. Evaluating source credibility and detecting misinformation;

B. Understanding data privacy and the Responsible Use Policy;

C. The environmental and social impacts of digital technologies;

D. Safe and respectful use of digital tools;

E. Skills to critically evaluate digital content;

F. Developing critical thinking, creativity, communication, collaboration, empathy, judgment, and independent problem-solving skills in a rapidly evolving technological world; and

G. Maintaining healthy technology habits, including attention management, period breaks, ergonomics, and awareness of persuasive or engagement-focused design.

VIII. PARENT AND GUARDIAN RIGHTS

Parents and legal guardians receive annual information about for their children's use of EdTech at school, including for the use of a school issued device and apps listed in the PPS digital toolkit.

The information will include: information regarding their child's use of digital tools, including estimated/actual total weekly time their child spends on a device; a complete list of apps, programs, Google Workspace Services; and information as to how those apps, programs, and websites were vetted to ensure they meet the standards and guidelines to have been deemed appropriate for educational and instruction use.

IX. DIGITAL TOOL VETTING AND APPROVAL PROCESS

PPS, in collaboration with the Technology Advisory Committee, will review and update the PPS Digital Technology and App Approval Process with a formal, transparent rubric to evaluate ed tech and digital tools. The rubric will consider targeted learning objectives, cognitive processes, student data privacy and safety, independent efficacy research, and time-bound requirements, adopting new student-facing digital products only when there are proven benefits over analog alternatives, and will include a process for teachers and staff to request approval for a new tool or app.

X. TECHNOLOGY AUDIT PROCESS

A. **Regular Technology Audit**. PPS will conduct annual audits of all digital tools and technologies currently in use across all grade levels and programs. These audits will evaluate: (i) continued compliance with approval criteria; (ii) actual learning outcomes achieved; (iii) any reported adverse effects on student privacy, learning, physical and mental health; (iv) budget impacts. The Technology Advisory Committee (discussed below) will review audit findings and make recommendations.

B. **Removal of Tools**. Any digital tool found to not meet approval criteria will be removed from use within ninety (90) days of such determination.

XI. ONGOING PROFESSIONAL SUPPORT

Educators will be provided training on the use of digital devices and platforms.

XII. STAKEHOLDER COLLABORATION

A. **Technology Advisory Committee.** PPS will maintain a Technology Advisory Committee that ideally includes technology personnel, educators, administrators, psychologists, students, and parents. The Committee will advise how technology is implemented throughout PPS, evaluating impacts on the learning and well-being of students and the community.

B. **Committee Responsibilities.** The Technology Advisory Committee will: (i) work with PPS to develop a digital tool rubric (ii) review and recommend updates to this Policy annually; (iii) evaluate proposed new technologies prior to adoption; (iv) monitor research and developments in educational technology and child health; (iv) collect information from parents, faculty, and staff regarding technology use; (v) evaluate outcomes of digital literacy curriculum and recommend changes as needed and (vi) report findings and recommendations to the school board as part of the District Annual Report.

XIII. MONITORING, ACCOUNTABILITY, AND CONTINUOUS IMPROVEMENT

A. **Policy Review.** The Technology Advisory Committee will review this Policy annually and make suggestions to the board to update as necessary based on current research, stakeholder feedback, and operational experience. The policy will be updated as needed to reflect new research, implementation feedback, equity analyses, and emerging tools and information. The first annual review will include feedback from students, educators, administrators, staff, parents, and families regarding policy implementation and data on screen time usage.

B. **District Annual Report to the Board.** PPS will provide an annual report to the Board, presented no later than August, detailing implementation of this Policy. The report will include, at minimum:

i. **Screen Time Data.** A summary of average student screen time across PPS, compared against the goals and benchmarks established under this Policy.

ii. **Digital Tools and Platforms in Use.** A current inventory of approved applications, digital tools, and commonly used websites utilized for instructional purposes and associated costs. Data on learning outcomes for each tool should be presented as well.

iii. **Digital and AI Literacy Curriculum.** An update on the implementation and status of digital and artificial intelligence literacy curricula, including progress made, instructional outcomes, and consistency of implementation across schools.

iv. **Data Privacy Incidents.** A summary of any student data privacy issues or incidents that arose during the school year, including the nature of each issue and the steps taken to address or mitigate it.

v. **Monitoring and Filtering Systems.** An update on the effectiveness of device monitoring and content-filtering systems, including efforts to ensure device use remains educational, minimizes access to distracting or non-instructional content, and maintains a safe digital environment for students. Include filtering mishaps and mitigation strategies.

vi. **Emerging Research.** A summary of relevant, current research on educational technology, screen use, and child development, and how such research may inform future updates to this Policy.

vii. **Disaggregation of Data.** Wherever possible, data provided under this section will be disaggregated by classroom, grade band, individual school, and historically underserved student groups, to allow the Board to identify disparities in implementation, access, or outcomes.

viii. **Technology Advisory Committee Findings and Recommendations.**

History: Adopted _____.